

The value of a gem

Whether they are collectable specimens, used in everyday jewellery, or incorporated into beautiful works of art, gemstones are viewed as highly prestigious objects in many – if not most – cultures. It could be argued that their value is entirely man-made, but the fact remains that fine gems represent an apex

of material quality, visual beauty, and fine craftsmanship. Diamonds are graded and valued in a slightly different way from other stones (see p.27) – the term “coloured stones” refers to all non-diamond gems, although diamonds can be coloured – but the core principles remain the same.

Gem qualities

All gemstones are valued according to four “Cs”: colour, clarity, cut, and carat. There is a final factor to add to these – their rarity. In general, larger stones are much rarer than smaller ones; for some stones, this means that an increase in weight can result in a disproportionately large price increase, so when a gemstone doubles in weight, its price may go up by four or five times.

Carat

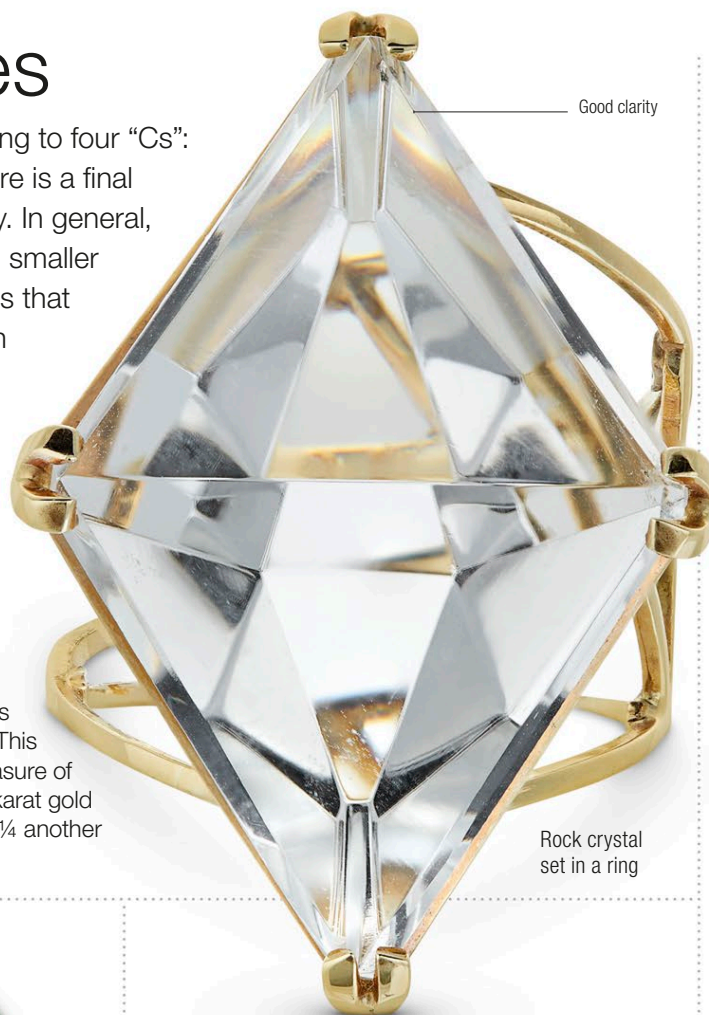
A carat is a measurement of a gemstone's weight, equivalent to one-fifth of a gram. This should not be confused with karat, a measure of the proportion of gold in a gold alloy. 24-karat gold is pure gold; 18-karat gold is $\frac{3}{4}$ gold and $\frac{1}{4}$ another metal, often copper.



Aquamarine in a round cut

Cut

A gemstone's cut is graded on the basis of its technical perfection, and the brilliance it produces. Considerations might include whether the points of triangular facets meet without overlap, or if the sides of rectangular step-cut facets are parallel.



Good clarity

Rock crystal set in a ring



Sherry topaz in a deep gold colour

Colour

The value attributed to a gemstone's colour is usually determined by its purity and intensity. However, in some cases, it may be due to the rarity of a particular colour. For example, natural red or blue diamonds command astronomical prices.



Goshenite showing excellent clarity

Clarity

Clarity refers to the lack of foreign matter – other minerals, hollows, or crystals – within the stone, known as inclusions. The resulting effect on the beauty of the stone determines value; although a lack of inclusions is valuable, certain types of inclusions are also desirable.

Rarity

The fifth characteristic

Rarity has a direct effect on value: a superb garnet will never command the same price as an equivalent ruby, simply because ruby is vastly rarer. Some stones usually occur only in small sizes due to their chemistry. In this case, larger stones are even rarer.



Excellent colour

Ruby